

that outlines what your partner should do or will inherit in the event of critical illness, injury, or death.

Get tech-savvy. This is not the time to be a Luddite. You want to know how to Skype your grandchildren, which will save you a fortune on long-distance bills. If you can afford to monetize a hobby, do it. You now have something that was once in short supply: time.

But what about the reader who's well past those prime earning decades and slouching toward retirement trailing a lot of debt and financial regret? When you're sixty years old, broke, and contemplating a sparse retirement, you start thinking about all the stupid crap you bought when you were younger. You have to stop that cycle of regret. It leads to a hopelessness that can only trigger inaction and depression. That money's gone and buried.

I'm a realist. I'm not going to tell you the next decades are going to be easy. It's time to throw out all those expectations you had about how life was going to be in your twilight years. It's time to start planning for something completely different. Here are some cold hard numbers: The average annual income from Social Security is barely over \$15,000. As we've seen, that goes up to \$25,000 for couples, and if you're a veteran you might qualify for additional government benefits. But that's it, folks. That's poverty-level retirement, no doubt, so you have to be savvy. And very strategic.

But if you're five to seven years away from retirement, you still have a few options to top off that income. You can see how even \$5,000 a year more will make all the difference in your quality of life. And if you live another fifteen years after retirement, you're really looking at saving only \$75,000 to get to that. You can do that in five to seven years. But you have to be ruthless.

If you're single or widowed, consider getting a roommate or a student boarder. Pooling resources is the smartest thing you can do right now. Radically cut down on all your expenses. Lose the car. Lose the cable. Maybe even lose the cat. You're in an emergency situation. You have to look at every expenditure with a critical eye and make tough decisions about cash flow. If you're fit, stay on that bike and walk everywhere. This will keep you healthy and, more crucially, will lift your mood. Consider downsizing a little sooner. Pick a place to